Parkdale Hub – Phase 3
Community Meeting

MEETING SUMMARY

Wednesday, March 8 2023
6:30 p.m. – 8:30 p.m., Virtual Meeting

Overview

On Wednesday, March 8, 2023, CreateTO hosted a Community Meeting for Phase 3 of the Parkdale Hub project. The purpose of the meeting was to share updates, and answer questions about Phase 3 of the Parkdale Hub Project *(see attachment A for the meeting agenda).* Approximately 100 people attended the meeting. Councillor Gord Perks and staff from his office, staff from City Planning, the Housing Secretariat, Toronto Public Library, Parks, Forestry & Recreation, Social Development Finance and Administration, and members of CreateTO's project consultant team also attended and participated in the meeting.

Following the land acknowledgement and welcoming remarks from Councillor Gord Perks, Matthew Wheatley, independent facilitator from Third Party Public, reviewed the agenda and facilitated a round of introductions. CreateTO, City Planning and DTAH & ERA (consultants leading the design of the demonstration plan) provided an update on the Parkdale Hub project and a recap of the demonstration plan. Participants then asked questions and shared comments through a facilitated discussion.

Third Party Public Inc., an independent facilitation team retained by CreateTO, facilitated the meeting and prepared this meeting summary and shared it with participants in draft for review prior to it being finalized. This summary is intended to reflect key discussion points from the meeting and is not intended to be a verbatim transcript.

Parkdale Pop-Up Engagement Events

Prior to the Community Meeting held on March 8th, the project team hosted two pop-ups in the community at the Parkdale Library on February 28th, and the Masaryk-Cowan Community Recreation Centre on March 3rd. Members of the project team set-up at both locations with information panels and invited community members to ask questions and share feedback. The same information shared at the community meeting was shared at the pop-ups. A summary of the feedback shared at the pop-ups is included at the end of this report, as Attachment B.

Key themes

The following key themes emerged during the discussion and are summarized below. These reoccurring themes should be read along with the more detailed summary of questions and comments that follow:

Strong support for affordable housing. Several participants discussed the importance of providing affordable and deeply affordable housing with some advocating for increased height and density to allow for more affordable housing. Participants also advocated for two- and three-bedroom affordable units to increase the supply of family-sized units in Parkdale.

Continued interest and excitement about the potential for the Parkdale Hub to respond to community needs. Participants are inspired by the community coming together and shared excitement for what the Parkdale Hub can become to serve the community.

Local community organizations and community members need to have an active role in the detailed design and operation of the Hub. Participants said it is important that local community priorities be addressed and reflected in the design and operation of the Hub. Some expressed concern that they did not see local priorities shared previously reflected in the current materials. Local priorities identified are included in the detailed sections of the summary below.

Clear and ongoing communication with the community. Participants discussed the importance of sharing clear and accurate information with the local community, especially those directly impacted by construction and changes to the existing facilities and services. There were some concerns about recent communications with Artscape tenants and requests for clarity on how their units will be protected and replaced.

Summary of questions and feedback

Following the presentation, participants asked questions and shared comments through a facilitated discussion. Participants were also encouraged to share any additional feedback and/or questions with the team after the meeting. This summary includes feedback and questions shared by participants at the meeting as well as feedback shared via email after the meeting. The questions and comments by participants are organized below, followed by responses and comments from the project team in *italics*, where provided.

Comments and questions about affordable housing

Affordable housing is a serious priority for the Parkdale community. Participants discussed the importance of using this public site to provide as much affordable housing as possible and operate it in a way that responds to the needs of the local community. Participants shared different ideas on how to do this, including:

- Consider making this co-operative housing and using the Woodsworth Housing Co-operative in St. Lawrence Market as an example;

- Partner with existing community organizations to create non-profit housing partnerships as local organizations know the strength of the neighbourhood and how to leverage this strength to support the community; and
- Increase the height and density to allow for more affordable units.

Ensure future presentations and materials shared speak to the connection between the Ontario Disability Support Program (ODSP) and affordable housing offered at Parkdale. Parkdale has a high percentage of people on ODSP, making it important to recognize and acknowledge their existence and desire to have access to affordable units. *Councillor Perks: We will take that as advice to ensure we list people on social assistance, particularly ODSP, as potential tenants on future Housing Now projects. What was presented today is the minimum requirements that the Housing Now plan calls for – our aim is to do much better than that.*

Provide clarity on plans for amending the City's definition of affordable housing and specifically if/how it will apply to 2-bedroom units. The City's website seems to indicate any amendments to definitions will not apply to two-bedroom units because they are seen as two-income households. If this is the case, it is short-sighted because we need more two- and three-bedroom affordable units and we need a revision to what is affordable to better support people, especially parents and others with dependents. *Note added after the meeting: Under the City's new income-based definition of affordable rental housing, the rents for two-bedroom units remain the same as 100% of average market rent (AMR). It should be noted that under Bill 23, which received Royal Assent last year, the Province defined affordable rental housing as 80% of AMR. The City continues to work with our partners at the Province and in City Planning to ensure there is consistency and an aligned approach on defining affordability.*

Comments and questions about the overall design and proposed development concept

A range of opinions and ideas about the proposed height and density. Some participants strongly advocated for increasing the height and density to allow for more affordable housing. They said because this is a government initiative, it is an opportunity to lead by example and allow for additional height and density to allow for additional affordable housing. Ideas shared on how to increase density and height included: increasing the height of building in the west block to 12-storyes and extending the footprint of the building in the west block to the south by removing the sidewalk, as the sidewalk at the back of the building will be hard to activate in a safe way, especially at night. A few other participants said the proposed height and density is appropriate for the area and will do a good job to provide a mixed-income development with affordable housing.

Increase the number of 3-bedroom units. A participant said that Parkdale currently has 2.5% of rental stock being 3-bedroom units, compared to the City of Toronto at 8.6%. There was also a concern raised that the private sector may not develop 3-bedroom units, so with this being a publicly owned site it is a unique opportunity to add those units. Additionally, a participant said there has been a reduction of children and youth in South Parkdale and including 3-bedroom units can help counter that trend in an intentional way.

Consider a massing step back of at least 20-30 metres on the east block, similar to what is proposed for the west block. It could be done above the third floor to create an angular plane of 45 degrees. This would give the community open sky space and views. To avoid cutting back on units, this revised plan can include a few additional storeys above the angular plane.

Please ensure the aesthetics of the building fit with the context of the neighbourhood. The flat glass retail spaces of condo-style buildings create dead space, and don't create an inviting presence for people to stop in the retail spaces. Also consider keeping the actual heritage buildings and not just the facades.

Is there any possibility of retaining some of the historical components, such as the gates, as part of the detail design? *Specific details about what will be retained will come at the detailed design stage. There will be a heritage impact assessment in the application that will explore what elements can be reused on the site. There will also be an interpretation plan that will look at creative opportunities for interpretation and commemoration of the history of the site. The community will continue to be engaged during the design process for the centre block.*

Please provide clarity on the 9 storeys being reported on the zoning application and the 10 storeys being presented in the presentation. *The submission originally proposed a height of 9-storeys for the west block. However, following a built form analysis, the submission was revised and the height of the West Block was increased to 10-storeys which is supported by the planning policies for this site and with support from Community Planning staff.*

There are important community priorities that have been shared previously and are missing from the presentation and proposed developed concept, including:

- small retail zoning and economic development opportunities, including opportunities for selling food;
- climate change priorities for mitigation and adaptation, including accessible green roofs, access to rooftop gardens and urban agriculture; and
- the legacy use of land for the Indigenous community in Parkdale.

There is no mention of public safety features built into the design, especially around semi-private walkways, and below-grade parking. With incidents rising in the City, it is important to address public safety. *Note added after the meeting: At the zoning stage, Crime Prevention through Environmental Design (CPTED) measures have been considered. Detailed safety considerations will be assessed and incorporated through the detailed design of each block.*

Consider including an outdoor water activation feature where kids can frolic through.

Amenity basics are needed for any community spaces such as a kitchen with a stove, fridge, and counters; and office spaces that are accessible to the local community.

Questions and comments about traffic, vehicular and bike parking

Will traffic flow on Milky Way Lane and/or Cowan Avenue be changed? *As part of this development, Milky Way Lane behind the East Block building will be widened and allow for two-way traffic from Cowan Avenue and the eastern boundary of the East Block. Cowan Avenue will remain the same with one-way traffic travelling southbound. The on-street WheelTrans drop-off and pick-up facility is proposed to be maintained.*

Will any parking spots on Cowan be lost? *No, there are not any plans to remove any on-street parking spaces on Cowan Avenue.*

How many new parking spaces will there be? *Approximately 41 new spaces will be provided for the Parkdale Hub.*

Will the parking lots next to Dollarama be replaced? *No, there are no plans to replace these parking spaces.*

Consider how to incorporate bike parking and bike renting facilities in the future detailed design work. *As part of the Landscape Plan, we are looking to maintain the bike stand outside the Parkdale Library. Long term bike parking can be provided within the buildings. There is a zoning requirement for short term and long term bike parking which we will secure in the zoning by-law and through the Site Plan applications.*

Ensure the physical bus stop/shelter is included in future designs/presentations.

Comments about Indigenous engagement

Indigenous engagement needs to happen, and the reports/summaries that capture the discussions and feedback shared need to be made accessible and easily available on the website. More than one participant discussed the importance of engaging with and listening to Indigenous groups and local urban Indigenous populations, especially during this time of Truth and Reconciliation. *Specific Indigenous engagement has not taken place to date as part of the Parkdale Hub process. Moving forward, CreateTO will make sure to include Indigenous engagement. As part of the Parkdale Heritage Conservation District (HCD) planning process, City staff connected with members of the local Indigenous community. Notes added after the meeting: As part of Parkdale HCD planning process, City staff participated in two meetings with the Niiwin Wendaanimak (Four Winds) program to speak with members of the local Indigenous community. Information about these two meetings are available on the City's website **here**. A summary of the discussion from the meeting held on May 3, 2022 is available on the City's website **here**. Further engagement for the library and community recreation centre lead by Toronto Public Library and Parks Forestry & Recreation will include Indigenous engagement.*

Comments and questions about environmental sustainability

Ensure the local greenery and trees will be protected during the construction phase of this project, and that there won't be loss of green space. *We will be adding green infrastructure into the community as part of public realm improvements. We will also be saving a mature tree on the site, which has resulted in some adjustments to the design of the building.*

This project has the opportunity to represent a commitment to sustainability, energy conservation and climate change. It is important that the buildings be LEED certified. *Councillor Perks: The city has Toronto Green Standard that requires all environmental work to be done upfront. We will look at every opportunity to make this the most sustainable building we can. Note added after the meeting: The housing sites on the East and West Blocks are required to achieve a minimum of Tier 2 of the Toronto Green Standards. The Centre Block is required to be built and designed to Net Zero Emissions as a City-owned facility.*

Is there an opportunity to integrate the green roof requirement with the community needs, so that instead of a green space that maintains itself there is an opportunity to have an active community garden? Use the Green Roof Garden Initiative at Toronto's Metropolitan University as an example of the best use of green roof space. Current green roof proposals are not accessible to the community. If this isn't included in the design, the green roof will not be accessible. *There are green roof requirements that need to be followed. We will also look into opportunities for gardening/agricultural facilities and if these would meet green roof requirements. We will also look at ways to ensure any green space, including green roofs, are made publicly accessible.*

Comments and questions about Artscape tenants and Gallery 1313

The residents of 1313 want more direct and clear communication from the City. They ask for the City to provide them with a document that states their tenancies will be protected and that their units will be replaced on the new site. They received a Notice of Rental Demolition Application that seem to be insensitive and untimely while still being in the consultation phase. The language on the notice was also disempowering because it said, "you will likely be offered a replacement unit at similar rent". *The notice tenants received was not a notice that the units would be demolished anytime soon, but that there has been an application submitted to the City that proposed the demolition of the units. It was meant to provide formal notice to tenants about the application outlining their rights and responsibilities, information and resources for tenants to look into, and opportunities for tenants to get involved with the process. Councillor Perks: We will make sure to get in touch with the tenant association to have a conversation about it. The rights of existing tenants are first and foremost and we will make sure your units are protected. Anytime there's a development application which imagines reconstructing, anyone who lives there gets that notice so that they have an opportunity to participate before the City decides to approve the rezoning. It is a necessary step to make sure that tenants know that if the City approves it, their rights are protected.*

Gallery 1313 is an important community space and provides vital services to the local community. Gallery 1313 provides a community service and public amenity space, but also has served Toronto's arts culture for 25 years, providing support and exhibit space to emerging and established artists and to students still in art schools. It is one of the few public non-profit galleries still operating in the city. Many others have folded due to the high costs of commercial space and the redevelopment of warehouses and related spaces. Gallery 1313 is a precious heritage institution that needs support to thrive in this process of creating a community hub.

Other comments

- One participant said the name, Parkdale Hub, should be changed because "hub" refers to other types of organizational structures, and it may create a mission drift to turn this into an actual hub instead of a centre. Consider Parkdale Centre or something similar.

Next steps

The project team thanked participants for their ongoing participation in the process, noting that this project has and will continue to work because of community involvement and leadership. The facilitation team reminded participants that they could share any additional feedback after the meeting via email. The facilitation team also told participants they would share a draft summary of the meeting for their review before finalizing it. Note added after the meeting: Following the review of feedback from the Community Meeting, and other commenting agencies, revised materials will be prepared and submitted to the City for review. The revised materials will be available on the City's Application Information Centre: http://app.toronto.ca/AIC/index.do?folderRsn=fVXai%2FqSiijJsAGrMv8rcg%3D%3D

Attachment A. Meeting Agenda

Parkdale Hub – Phase 3

Community Meeting

Wednesday, March 8, 2023

6:30 – 8:30 pm

Meeting held online via Zoom

Meeting purpose: to share updates, and answer questions about phase 3 of the Parkdale Hub Project.

6:30 Welcome, land acknowledgement, introductions, agenda review

Cllr Perks, CreateTO, Third Party Public

6:45 Presentation

7:15 Questions & Discussion

8:25 Wrap up and next steps

8:30 Adjourn

Attachment B. Pop-Up Feedback

Parkdale Hub – Phase 3
Community Pop ups

Pop-Up Summary

Tuesday February 28 and Friday March 3
3:00 – 5:00 p.m. and 9:00 – 12:00 p.m.

Overview

On Tuesday February 28 and Friday March 3, CreateTO hosted 2 community pop-ups for phase 3 of the Parkdale Hub project. The two community pop-ups took place at the Toronto Public Library – Parkdale Branch on February 28th, and at Masaryk-Cowan Community Recreation Centre on March 3rd. The purpose of the pop-ups were to share information, answer questions about the status of Parkdale Hub, increase awareness of the project, promote the upcoming Community Meeting, and engage local community members who might not participate in the Community Meeting. Approximately 50 people attended the two pop-ups. CreateTO, staff from City Planning, the Housing Secretariat, Toronto Public Library, Parks, Forestry and Recreation, and Social Development Finance and Administration participated in the pop-ups.

Members of the project team set-up at both locations with information panels and invited community members to ask questions and share feedback. The project team displayed 10 boards about the Parkdale Hub, which included:

- Information on the Community Meeting;
- Information on what the Parkdale Hub is and what the plans for it are;
- Timeline, including the proposed construction phasing;
- Information about Housing Now, including how to access housing opportunities;
- Information on the Toronto Public Library Parkdale Branch and Masaryk-Cowan Community Recreation Centre phasing; and
- Information about the future public engagement process for the detailed design of the library and community recreation centre.

Summary of questions and feedback

Overall support and excitement for the Parkdale Hub, and an interest to see it be built fast. Participants said they'd like to see the Hub become operational as soon as possible.

<u>Comments about affordability</u>

Strong support for affordable housing. Participants generally supported the development of affordable housing with several advocating for building as much affordable housing as possible and including deeply affordable units. Participants also shared comments and asked questions they want to see answered through the process, including:

- More information on how to apply for the affordable units.
- The definition of affordable housing for this site.

- Rent-Geared-to-Income units should be included for site and across the Housing Now Initiative.
- Clarify the total number of residential units and how many will be affordable.
- Will local residents have priority on the waitlist for affordable units?
- Will the interiors of the market and affordable units look the same?
- What is the difference between supportive housing, affordable housing and social housing (TCHC)?
- Can there be housing built in the Center block on top of the Toronto Public Library?
- How will the different housing units be grouped, managed and administered?

Comments about form and the proposed development concept

Ensure the building materials fit in with the aesthetics of the area. Use nearby buildings as examples, such as the health centre, the southwest corner of Springhurst Avenue and King Street West.

Support for building the site to be environmentally sustainable. Some participants said it's good to follow high environmental standards, and to consider mass timber as a material to use. Participants said the final built form and public realm should be built beautifully with green space and gardens for all to enjoy.

Concern about how the Parkdale Hub is being developed and what will be lost. One participant shared strong concerns that development of the Parkdale Hub is being done to the community, not by the community. They also shared concerns about the loss of the library in its current state and location and that people who use the current library and community recreation centre would be displaced by the redevelopment.

Protect the existing green space and trees. Participants discussed the importance of the park and trees around the existing buildings. They also said they would like to see more trees and greenspace in the area.

There was some concern regarding the built form. One participant asked the team to consider increasing the step back above the third storey of the west block.

Some participants had questions about parking, including:

- Will there be more public parking spaces included?
- How many parking spaces will be built for the new units?

Comments on community space and programming

There was interest in the local community spaces, with one participant saying those spaces should include a dedicated dance studio and industrial kitchen for community programming. Other participants shared interest in community spaces that sells produce.

Consider more senior programming in the community centre. It is good to see programming coming together in the library and community centre space. However, there is not enough current programming for seniors. Also consider including more music programs for all ages.

Some participants would like to see more Artscape rental units, as well as general space for artists.

Comments on Masaryk Cowan Community Recreation Centre and the Parkdale Library branch

There was general support for the preliminary designs of the library and community recreation centre. Some participants encouraged the team to hold more in-person engagement activities with the community during the detailed design of the library and community recreation centre.